

Buddhism



Siddhartha Gautama, later known as the Buddha, was born in India in the sixth-century BCE and brought up in the religious tradition of belief in a cycle of birth and rebirth. He gave up his comfortable background and adopted an austere lifestyle in a quest for release from this cycle, but realized this was not leading to a life of fulfilment either. He reasoned there was a 'middle way' between the extremes of sensual pleasure and asceticism (anticipating the idea of the Golden Mean, see [Ethics and the Golden Mean](#)). Life is characterized by suffering, caused by unfulfillable desires. We can avoid this suffering by overcoming our egos and giving up

‘attachments’ to worldly power and possessions. He summed this idea up in the Four Noble Truths: those of suffering, of the origin of suffering, of the end of suffering and of the ‘Eightfold Path’ to the end of suffering. By following the Eightfold Path (right mindfulness, right action, right intention, right livelihood, right effort, right concentration, right speech and right understanding), we can lead a life of fulfilment and escape the cycle of rebirth to achieve a state of *nirvana*.